

SKOAR!

KINGDOMS OF AMALUR RECKONING

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Kingdoms of Amalur: Reckoning is a single-player action RPG set on the mythical world of Amalur, and limited to the Faelands – one of the kingdoms. The player, or protagonist dies before the game begins, and is resurrected in the first and only successful experiment at the Well of Souls. Every individual fate is apparently a thread tied into the tapestry of the world's overall destiny. By dying only to return, the protagonist no longer has a predetermined fate, and becomes the highly influential "Fateless One."

In the main quest, what follows is the Fateless One's journey to save the world from a fated defeat in the Crystal War, where the Tuatha Deohn, the Winter Fae worshippers of false god Tirnoch led by Gadflow, battle for domination against humans, elves, and the immortal Fae.

The storyline of KoA: Reckoning was a little too pulpy to deliver a fresh or interesting take on themes common in this genre. However, even pulp usually possesses a few redeeming qualities, at least some strong humour, ominous intrigue, well-crafted atmospherics – none of which feature strongly in KoA: Reckoning's script.

Gameplay

At the beginning of the game, the protagonist can choose from four playable races, two human and two Elfin, each with different initial 'skill bonuses'. Skills are alchemy, blacksmithing, detect hidden, dispelling, mercantile, persuasion, sagecraft, and stealth.

There are three ability trees, namely finesse, might and sorcery, and depending on how players invest in these, various destiny types will open up, from Fateless One, to Rogue, Mage, Fighter, their combinations, and Jack of All Trades, each with their own classes.

Players level up by investing in abilities and skills, with XP points awarded for combat, disarming traps, picking locks, and quest achievements. Players also earn fate points. There's plenty to keep you gripped.

A lot has been made about the combat mechanics of KoA: Reckoning, something that is admittedly missing in the RPG genre, and games like Dragon Age. Great care was taken to ensure the combat mechanics of KoA: Reckoning were more controllable and satisfying, and the game makers have succeeded in making the action-RPG feel like a hack-and-slash. Don't expect Devil May Cry-level of timing and direction perfection here though.

Through the game, the player picks up a variety of weapons, each with its special abilities and bonuses, but split across categories. Combat is a remarkable sight, with particle effects and motion trails, and in most cases, extra effects like ice, lightning, fire, and venom. Each weapon will get various moves unlocked during the game, such as block, charge, parry and dodge moves. Abilities also unlock powers such as Quake, Ice Barrage, Lunge, and Shadow Flare.

Graphics

The game has very decent graphics, with realistic textures, and excellent animation effects. I played it on a moderately pow-

erful PC, and got smooth frame rates above 100 fps at maximum graphics settings. The game's design is also quite good, with interesting landscapes, well thought-out character models, and lovingly detailed weapons and armour.

The voice acting in the game is top-notch, as are the sound effects. However, the game's neoclassical music style gets boring after a while, becoming highly repetitive, even in some of the major sequences.*

Verdict

Overall, Kingdoms of Amalur: Reckoning is a fun game that is definitely worth a single play-through, if only to enjoy the myriad of weapons, powers and abilities on offer. After a certain level though, you may just get bored of your omnipotence – lose interest in progressing through the game.

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- » **Platforms:** Xbox 360, PlayStation 3, and Windows
- » **Price:** ₹2,599, ₹2,799, and ₹999 respectively
- » **Developer:** 38 Studios, Big Huge Games
- » **Publisher:** EA Games

